

Level of Difficulty

To achieve marks in the higher bands, candidates need to demonstrate their skills and understanding in a performance of pieces which demand a level of complexity, technical challenge and musical understanding comparable to those typically found in the syllabuses of the *conservatoire* examining bodies at grades IV/V.

To achieve marks in the medium bands, candidates need to demonstrate their skills and understanding in a performance of pieces which demand a level of complexity, technical challenge and musical understanding comparable to those typically found in the syllabuses of the *conservatoire* examining bodies at grades III/IV.

The level of difficulty of the music presented will influence the marks under Assessment Criteria heading 2 – Technical control across a range of techniques and heading 4 – Aural and stylistic understanding.

A range of exemplar material, which shows how each of the marking criteria will take account of 'level of difficulty' across representative mark bands, is available within the Guidance for Teachers booklet (see OCR website for more detail).

1. Knowledge and fluency (of pitch and rhythm)

In this section, examiners assess candidates' knowledge of the music being performed. In improvisatory styles; knowledge refers to the decisions made by the candidate in terms of pitch and/or rhythm as appropriate to the instrument and style.

13–15 marks	The candidate demonstrates a thorough knowledge of notes and rhythms and the performance is completely fluent.
10–12 marks	The candidate demonstrates a mainly secure knowledge of notes and rhythms; some mistakes, but not enough to disturb the basic fluency of the performance.
7–9 marks	The candidate demonstrates a moderate knowledge of the notes and rhythm; a number of mistakes disturb the fluency of some parts of the performance.
4–6 marks	The candidate demonstrates an erratic knowledge of the notes and rhythms; hesitancy sometimes seriously impairs the fluency of the performance.
1–3 marks	The candidate demonstrates poor knowledge of notes and rhythms, showing persistent hesitancy and little fluency throughout the performance.

0 marks	The music is marred by inaccuracies and significant rhythmic hesitancy with no sense of the fluency required for a coherent performance.
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2. Technical control across a range of techniques

Assessed under this heading: quality, variety and evenness of tone; the range of technical skills displayed; specific factors as they apply to the candidate's instrument/voice (e.g. co-ordination of RH/LH, bow/fingers, tongue/fingers; intonation; breath control; diction; pedalling; registration).

13–15 marks	The candidate demonstrates very secure technical control in every respect, across a wide range of advanced techniques.
10–12 marks	The candidate demonstrates mainly secure technical control of the instrument in all significant respects, across a range of fairly advanced techniques.
7–9 marks	The candidate demonstrates moderate technical control with problems in some areas, across a limited range of moderately advanced techniques.
4–6 marks	The candidate demonstrates erratic technical control, with significant problems in some areas, across a narrow range of techniques.
1–3 marks	The candidate demonstrates poor technical control of the instrument, with significant problems in several areas, across a limited range of techniques.
0 marks	The candidate is not in technical control of the instrument.

3. Realisation of performance markings and/or performing conventions

Assessed under this heading: the realisation of markings written into the score by the composer and/or the observance of appropriate performing conventions (e.g. ornamentation, *notes inégales* and other Baroque rhythmical alterations, swung quavers and other jazz conventions).

13–15 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are convincingly realised throughout the performance and/or appropriate performing conventions are effectively applied.
10–12 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are realised throughout most of the performance and/or some appropriate performing conventions are applied.
7–9 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are realised in some passages in the performance and/or some appropriate performing conventions are inconsistently applied.
4–6 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are inconsistently realised in some passages in the performance and/or few performing conventions are applied.
1–3 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are seldom realised throughout most of the performance and/or performing conventions are largely ignored.
0 marks	Markings of tempo, expression, articulation and phrasing are ignored throughout the performance and/or no performing conventions are observed.

4. Aural and stylistic understanding

Where candidates present their recitals with an accompanist, the ability to co-ordinate with the accompanist is taken into account when awarding marks in this category. In improvisatory styles, the candidates' ability to extend their part in ways appropriate to the chosen style is also considered here. Aural awareness also pertains to choices made by candidates in terms of amplification.

13–15 marks	The candidate demonstrates acute aural awareness and a well-developed sense of a relevant range of styles throughout a performance which communicates a coherent understanding of the music.
10–12 marks	The candidate demonstrates good aural awareness and a fairly well-developed sense of a relevant range of styles, throughout a performance which communicates a mainly coherent understanding of the music.
7–9 marks	The candidate demonstrates fairly good aural awareness and a moderate sense of style through most of a performance which communicates a general understanding of most of the music.
4–6 marks	The candidate demonstrates some aural awareness and some sense of style through parts of a performance which communicates a limited understanding of the music.
1–3 marks	The candidate demonstrates little aural awareness or sense of style throughout a performance which communicates very little understanding of the music.
0 marks	The candidate demonstrates no aural awareness, sense of style or understanding in any of the music.